

The Claremont City Council held a Special meeting on Thursday, March 5, 2020, in the Council Chambers of City Hall.

The meeting was called to order by Assistant Mayor Damren at 6:30 p.m.

Members of the Council present were:

Ward I Councilor Andrew O’Hearne
At-Large Councilor Abigail Kier
At-Large Councilor Erica Sweetser
Assistant Mayor Allen Damren
At-Large Councilor Debora Matteau
At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski
Ward II Councilor James Contois
Ward III Councilor Jonathan Stone

Absent:

Mayor Charlene Lovett

Also present:

Edward Morris, City Manager

CITIZEN’S FORUM

None

NEW BUSINESS

Compensation Study Presentation (City Manager)

Dr. Rick Campbell, Paypoint HR, talked about his company, the process he’ll use, and the communities he’ll use for comparison.

Dr. Campbell said that having this study shows that fair pay is important to the Council. In terms of the process, they have done this for communities across the country. Each community is unique. Paypoint HR strongly believes in employee engagement. Employees will fill out a job survey. What they do may be different than what is on the job description. Supervisors will check the surveys. All employees are encouraged to participate. His job is not to give pay raises. His job is to present the facts. They will come back in the second week in April to do focus groups with employees; this is voluntary. Employees and supervisors will not be in the same room. Some questions will be: “Do you have the tools and technology to do your job well?; “Strategic vision for the City, how is it relevant to the

employees?; Do they know the vision?” Focus groups are anonymous and won’t be fact checked. Dr. Campbell said he has a PhD in chemical engineering and his wife, Karin, has a background in HR. They also have additional support staff. They will look for comparators within a 100-mile radius of Claremont. They will look at median household income, cost of living, housing prices, unemployment rate, and labor force participation rate. They will compare those with the same data as Claremont. They will collect data and the knowledge and skills of employees. Regarding implementation, they will update job descriptions and make sure most duties are not “other duties as assigned.” For every job title, they will see what the market is. They will find out what percentile the City wants to be at. He will calculate the physical impact of that and look at benefits. Oftentimes the dollar amounts for these can be big, so he will look at the positions that are most out of line.

Councilors asked clarifying questions. Regarding the 100-mile radius, Dr. Campbell said currently, all areas they are looking at are in NH.

Mr. Morris said one reason the Merit Plan review was talked about is because a lot of employees are at the top of their pay range. The City is having to hire people at the top of the pay range, because we cannot recruit if we do not do that. Part of the problem is we set pay minimum and maximum pay ranges, that don’t adjust to keep up with market. He talked with Dr. Campbell about having a plan to adjust with the market, so this study will last a little longer.

Mr. Morris said he is a big proponent of fair pay and treating employees fairly.

When asked, Dr. Campbell confirmed this study will include every job title.

Dr. Campbell said the estimated time for the first cut of numbers will be by mid-May; the focus groups will be held two weeks before then. The goal is to empower the Council to be able to make decisions.

Mr. Morris said the thought is not to unveil this for the budget, but to make a small start. He has asked for a finished product by the end of summer. He would like to put something in this budget for people. We’ll have to see how the budget numbers come out.

Regarding employees with higher salaries, Mr. Morris said we would look at the overall implementation and on the Merit side, maybe we can shift some possible future raises to some of the people that are lower to help equal that playing field. He has been discussing with the unions that everyone needs to work together as a group. There will be no reneging on union contracts. The City needs to look at the long-term strategy of what the Council decides to do.

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None

ADJOURNMENT

At 7:26 p.m., a motion was made by Mr. O’Hearne and seconded by Ms. Matteau to adjourn.

Voice vote: motion carried 8-0.

Respectfully Submitted,

Dorée M. Russell
Clerk to the Council